

Seawall height in Islamorada

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

ISLAMORADA • MONROE COUNTY

No minimum set in local code

Islamorada's Village Code sets no minimum or maximum seawall top elevation in any datum. It is one of the strictest hardening codes in the Keys: vertical seawalls are barred on open water, and a damaged seawall is to be repaired with riprap and native plants unless riprap is shown not to be feasible.

The detail

NO FIXED ELEVATION	Islamorada Village Code Sec. 30-1545, Bulkheads, seawalls or riprap, sets no seawall top elevation in NAVD88, NGVD29 or any other datum.
OPEN WATER	New vertical seawalls or bulkheads are not permitted on open water except under F.S. 373.414(5). Vertical seawalls as defined in Rule 62-330, F.A.C., shall not be permitted. Sec. 30-1545(a) and (b).
ALTERED SHORELINES	Hardening with bulkheads, seawalls and other vertical structures may be permitted only to stabilize severely eroding shorelines under Rule 62-330.0501(12), F.A.C., and the conditions in subsection (e). Sec. 30-1545(c).
RETENTION BEHIND THE WALL	The design must include a minimum six-inch retention swale, berm or curb directly landward of the system. Sec. 30-1545(b) and (e)(5).
REPAIRS	A deteriorated, lawfully existing seawall may be repaired or replaced, keeping the existing footprint to the maximum extent practicable. Damaged seawalls shall be repaired using riprap with native shoreline vegetation, and bulkheads are permitted only if riprap with filter cloth is not feasible. Sec. 30-1545(g).
CAP WIDTH	A seawall may have a cap up to two feet wide without being considered a dock. Sec. 30-1545(i).
SETBACK	The shoreline setback does not apply to seawalls, retaining walls, riprap and bulkheads permitted under the division. Sec. 30-1542(c).

Where this comes from: Islamorada, Village of Islands, Village Code Ch. 30 Land Development Regulations, Sec. 30-1545 (Bulkheads, seawalls or riprap); also Sec. 30-1542 and Sec. 6-94.4

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.